

User Manual

PlanInk 1.0.0

Braden Dougherty
Lucas Landrus
Christopher Nguyen
Abdullah Orynbassar

Group 5

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1 Introduction

PlanInk can be found at <https://turing.cs.olemiss.edu:3005>

Note: Requires web browser to have relaxed certificate validation protocol, such as Firefox or Safari

1.1 Purpose

The object of this user manual is to provide clients with the tools and knowledge necessary to utilize our system. Our current system is built for the University of Mississippi Engineering school, with scalability expected in later releases. Included will be notes for our different user types including engineering students, academic advisors, faculty, as well as development notes. The user will understand how to create and login to their account, and be able to use the features available to them, with detailed sections for each user role.

1.2 Overview

Our system is aimed at helping students, advisors, and faculty plan for future semesters. Students often feel overwhelmed and confused when scheduling classes for later semesters, while advisors can struggle to help students who may not know what their options and requirements are. Below are capabilities for each user role:

Students:

- Can view current, advisor approved schedule
- Can view completed courses, and courses still left to take
- Can view further information about courses for clarity (Prerequisites, credits, description, etc)
- Can build a future schedule plan with an easy interface, save, and submit to advisor for review

Advisors:

- Can see list of all students assigned to them, with ability to filter and search for individuals
- Ability to filter for students with schedules to review
- Further ability to accept or reject proposed schedules
- Can view an individual student's completed courses
- Can send messages to individual students to provide notes and guidance
- Can view change log of programs

Faculty:

- Can view available majors
- Can update requirements for specific majors
- Can update individual courses
- Can view change log of programs

1.3 System Requirements

- User must have internet access
- User must use a web browser capable of permitting user-initiated exceptions for TLS/SSL certificate validation failures. (e.g. Firefox)

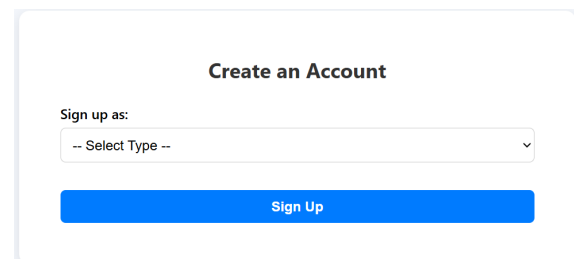
1.4 Version 1.0.0 Release

This 1.0.0 release is geared towards the Computer science branch of the school of Engineering. With that being said, the currently supported majors include BSCS (Bachelor of Computer Science) and BSDS (Bachelor of Data Science). Our system is designed such that scalability is in the immediate future, and will be able to support a wider range of majors.

2 Creating Accounts

2.1 Creating An Account

When visiting the website, the login page is set up as shown below. To begin creating an account, select the “signup” button. After this, a signup page will appear as shown.



2.1.1 Creating Student Account

To begin, select “Student” in the dropdown menu.

The left screenshot shows the 'Create an Account' form with the 'Sign up as:' dropdown menu open, displaying 'Student', 'Advisor', and 'Faculty' options. A red arrow points to 'Student' with the text 'Select student'.

The right screenshot shows the full 'Create an Account' form. Red arrows point to the following fields with instructions:

- 'Full Name', 'Email', and 'Student ID' fields: 'Fill out these three fields according to your information'
- 'Major' dropdown: 'Select your major'
- 'Advisor' dropdown: 'Select your assigned advisor'
- 'Graduation Date - Semester' and 'Graduation Date - Year' dropdowns: 'Select your graduation date, and set password'

After submitting the form, you will be redirected to the login page.

2.1.2 Creating Advisor Account

To begin, select advisor from the drop down menu.

The left screenshot shows the 'Create an Account' form with the 'Sign up as:' dropdown menu open, displaying 'Student', 'Advisor', and 'Faculty' options. A red arrow points to 'Advisor' with the text 'Select Advisor'.

The right screenshot shows the full 'Create an Account' form for an advisor. Red arrows point to the following fields with instructions:

- 'Full Name' field: 'Enter Full name, email'
- 'Advisor PIN' field: 'Enter provided pin number'
- 'Password' field: 'Enter password'

To prevent bad actors from creating advisors and faculty users, sample pins were created. The advisor pin is **1111**. After filling out and submitting the form, the user will be redirected to the login page.

To reset the pin, contact our team. (Contact available at end)

2.1.3 Creating Faculty Account

To begin, select faculty from the dropdown menu.

The image shows two parts of the 'Create an Account' form. The left part shows the 'Sign up as' dropdown menu with 'Faculty' selected. The right part shows the full form with fields for 'Full Name', 'Email', 'Faculty PIN', and 'Password'. Red arrows point to each field with labels: 'Enter full name and email' for Full Name, 'Enter provided pin number' for Faculty PIN, and 'Enter password' for Password. A 'Sign Up' button is at the bottom.

To prevent bad actors from creating advisors and faculty users, sample pins were created. The faculty pin is **2222**. After filling out and submitting the form, the user will be redirected to the login page.

To reset the pin, contact our team. (Contact available at end)

2.2 Logging In

Follow the shown steps to log in to your respective user portal.

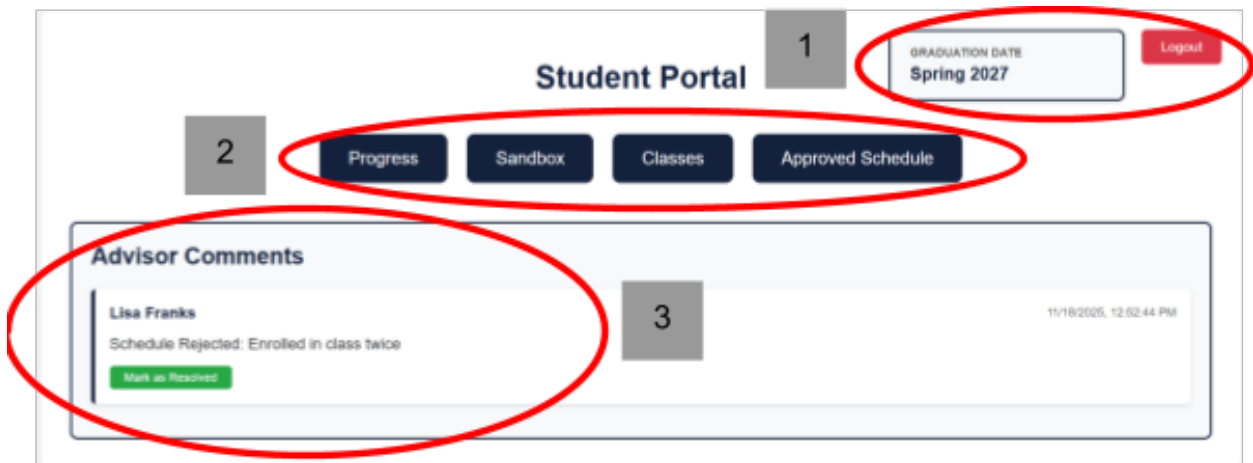
The image shows the 'Degree Planner' login page. It has a 'Log In' title. Below it are two input fields: 'Username' and 'Password'. Below these are three radio buttons: 'Student', 'Faculty', and 'Advisor'. At the bottom is a 'Log In' button and a 'Signup' button. Red arrows point to each field with labels: 'Enter Username and password' for Username, 'Select the user type the account was created for' for the radio buttons, and 'After these steps, select "Log In"' for the Log In button.

3 Students

3.1 Student Portal

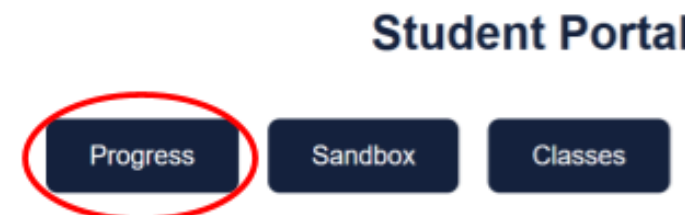
The student portal consists of the following sections:

1. In this section, the student can see their anticipated graduation date, as well as a logout button to end their session.
2. In this section, the student can access another page (Full functionality explained in sections 3.1.1–3.1.4)
 - **Progress** - Student can view completed courses, as well as completed hours out of required total hours for their major
 - **Sandbox** - Interactive user interface to build future schedules that can be submitted to advisor
 - **Classes** - Student can view full list of relevant courses to their major
 - **Approved Schedule** - Students can view their advisor-approved schedule
3. In this section, comments that the advisor has sent to the student are available to see
 - These comments can either be schedule rejection comments (The submitted schedule needs to be tweaked), or general comments.
 - The green “Mark as Resolved” button clears the comment from the student portal



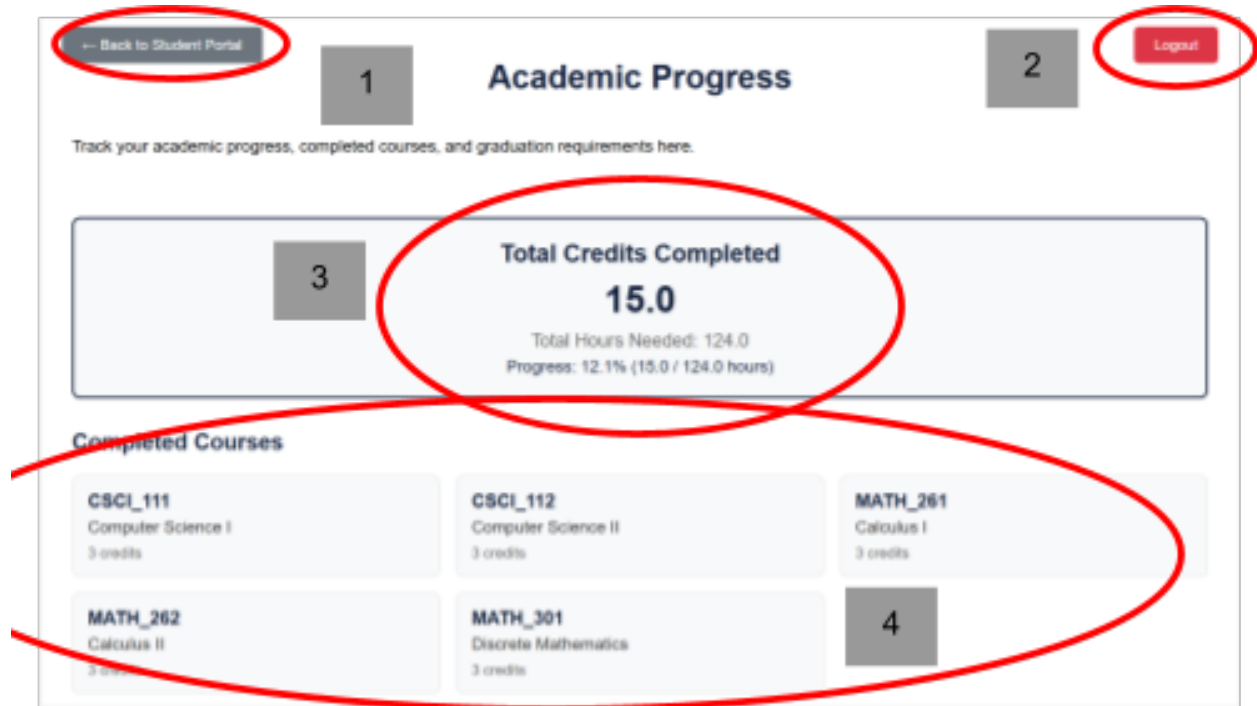
3.1.1 Student Progress

To access this page, begin by selecting the “Progress” button in the student portal.



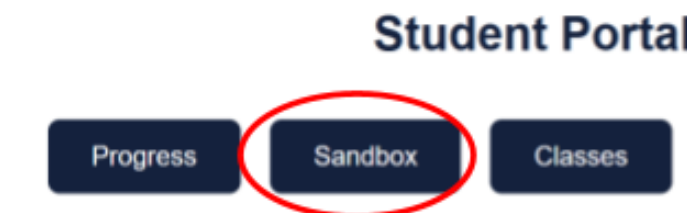
1. This “Back to Student Portal” button returns the student to the student portal.

2. Included logout button to end session
3. This section displays the total number of hours completed for the student, as well as the number of hours needed to complete their degree.
4. This section displays the courses that have been completed for the student.

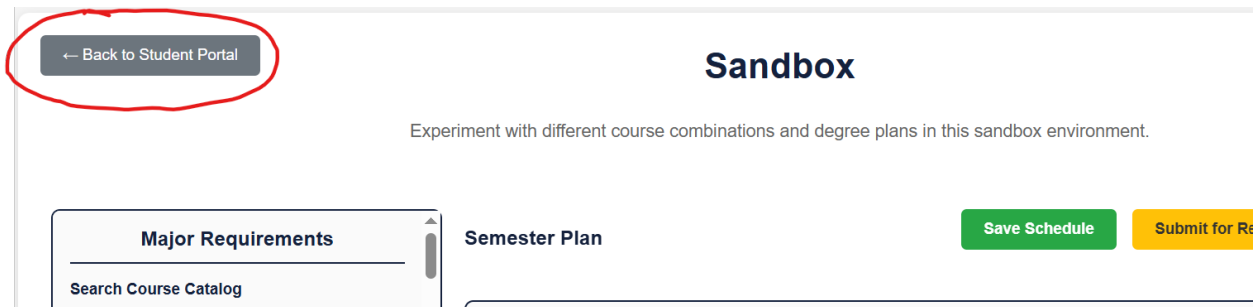


3.1.2 Student Sandbox

To begin, select the “Sandbox” button in the student portal.



1. This “Back to Student Portal” button returns the student to the student portal.

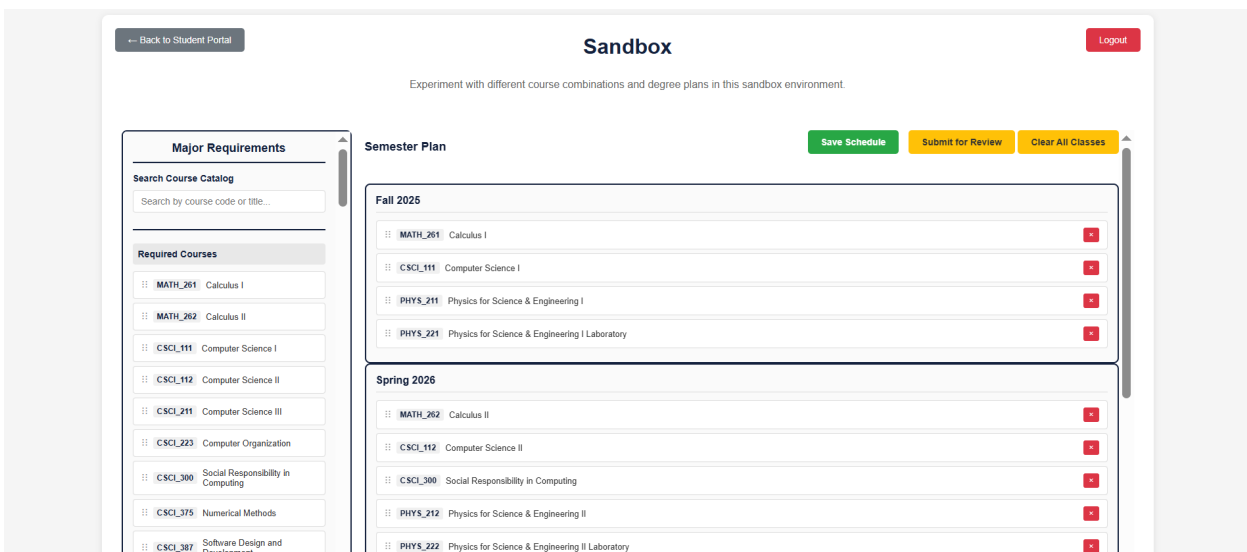


3.1.3 Sandbox — Building a Schedule

The Sandbox is the primary tool students use to construct future schedules. It provides a drag-and-drop interface where courses are represented as cards that can be placed into term columns. The sandbox preserves prerequisite warnings and highlights courses that conflict by time or requirement.

Key features:

- Drag-and-drop course cards between terms and remove courses with the **Remove** action.
- Real-time prerequisite checking and visual indicators for unmet requirements.
- Credit hour totals per term and cumulative totals for planned terms.
- Save drafts locally to continue later, or submit to your advisor for review.

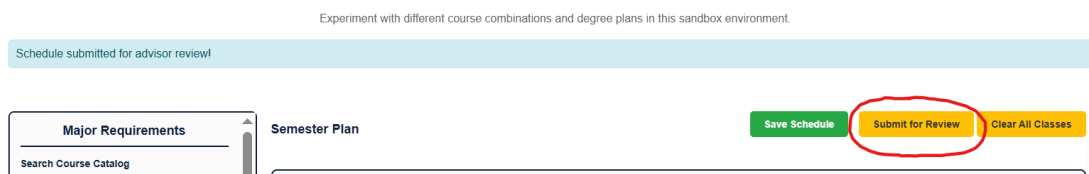


3.1.4 Saving and Submitting a Sandbox

Students can save a sandbox draft at any time using the **Save** button. To request advisor review, use the **Submit to Advisor** button which creates a pending submission entry visible to both the student and assigned advisor.

When submitting:

- Add an optional message to the advisor explaining special requests or constraints.
- The submission is time-stamped and appears in the advisor's *Schedules to Review* list.
- If the advisor requests changes, the submission returns to the student's sandbox with advisor comments attached.

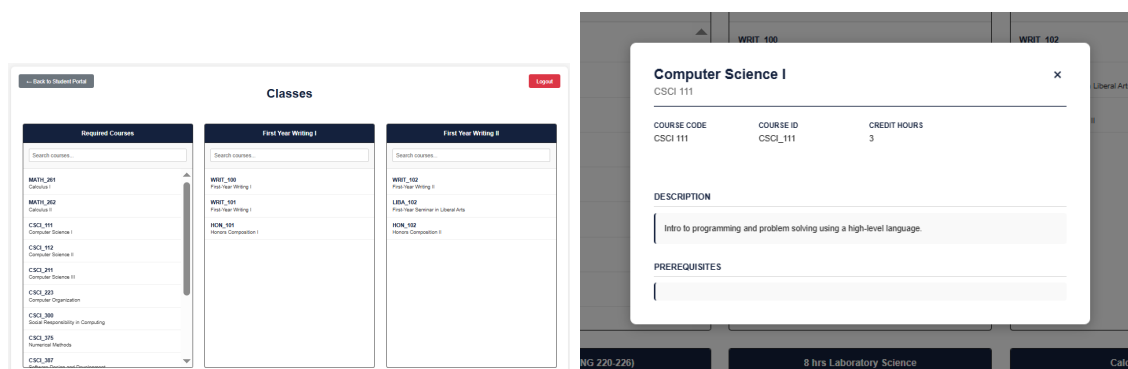


3.1.5 Classes

The **Classes** view lists all courses relevant to the student's major and minor (where applicable). Students can search, filter by subject or level, and open detail views for each course to view prerequisites, credits, and descriptions.

Functions available in the Classes view:

- Search bar to find courses by name or code.
- Filters for subject area, elective vs required, and credit hours.
- Click a course to open an information panel with full description, prerequisites, and suggested terms.
- From the course panel, use **Add to Sandbox** to place the course into the current sandbox term.



3.1.6 Approved Schedule

The **Approved Schedule** view shows the student's current advisor-approved course plan. Approved schedules are read-only for students; any further changes should be made in the Sandbox and re-submitted for approval.

What to expect in the Approved Schedule:

- A semester-by-semester layout mirroring the sandbox but locked for editing.
- Approval metadata including approving advisor name and approval date.
- A **Request Change** button to notify the advisor if an approved schedule requires modification.

← Back to Student Portal
Approved Schedule
Logout

This is your advisor-approved schedule. This schedule is read-only and cannot be edited.

Fall 2025

MATH_261 Calculus I
CSCI_111 Computer Science I
PHYS_211 Physics for Science & Engineering I
PHYS_221 Physics for Science & Engineering I Laboratory

Spring 2026

MATH_262 Calculus II
CSCI_112 Computer Science II
CSCI_300 Social Responsibility in Computing
PHYS_212 Physics for Science & Engineering II
PHYS_222 Physics for Science & Engineering II Laboratory

Fall 2026

CSCI_211 Computer Science III
CSCI_223 Computer Organization
SPCH_105 Business & Professional Speech

Spring 2027

No courses scheduled

3.1.7 Notifications and Messages

Students receive notifications when advisors comment on a submission, when approvals are made, and when account-related events occur. Notifications appear in the student portal header and in the messages panel.

- Click a notification to navigate to the related sandbox or comment thread.
- Use the messages panel to send or reply to advisor communications; mark messages as resolved to clear them from the primary portal view.

Progress
Sandbox
Classes
Approved Schedule

Advisor Comments

Lisa Franks
11/18/2025, 12:52:44 PM

Schedule Rejected: Enrolled in class twice

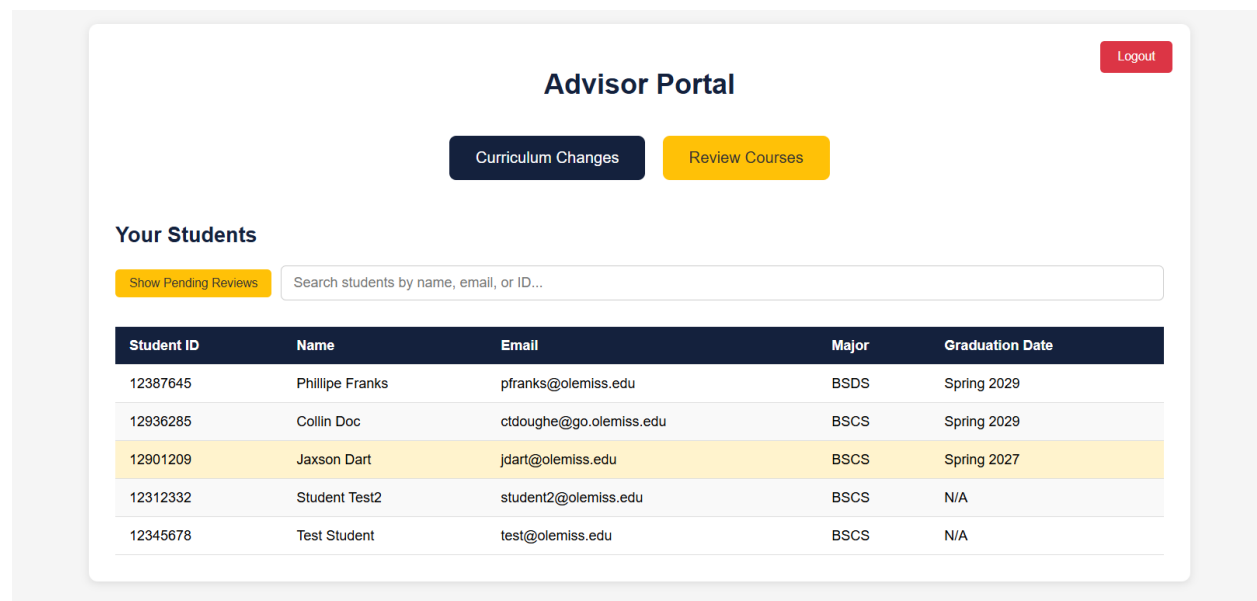
Mark as Resolved

4 Advisors

4.1 Advisor Portal

The advisor portal is designed to help academic advisors efficiently review and manage student schedules. Main features include a searchable student list, quick filters for schedules pending review, and direct message ability for student guidance.

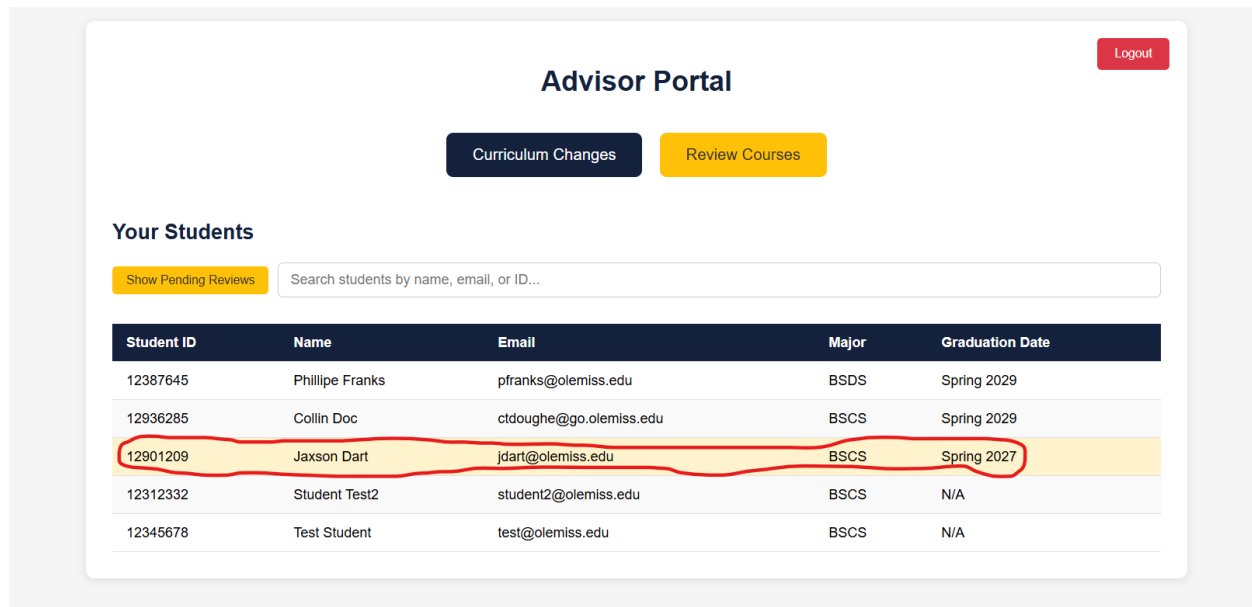
1. The header includes the advisor's name, a logout button, and a quick summary of schedules awaiting review.
2. In the left navigation, advisors can access: **Students**, **Schedules to Review**, **Change Log**, and **Messages**.
3. The central area displays the selected student's profile and submitted sandbox schedule for review.
4. The right panel includes quick actions: approve, request changes, or send a message to the student.



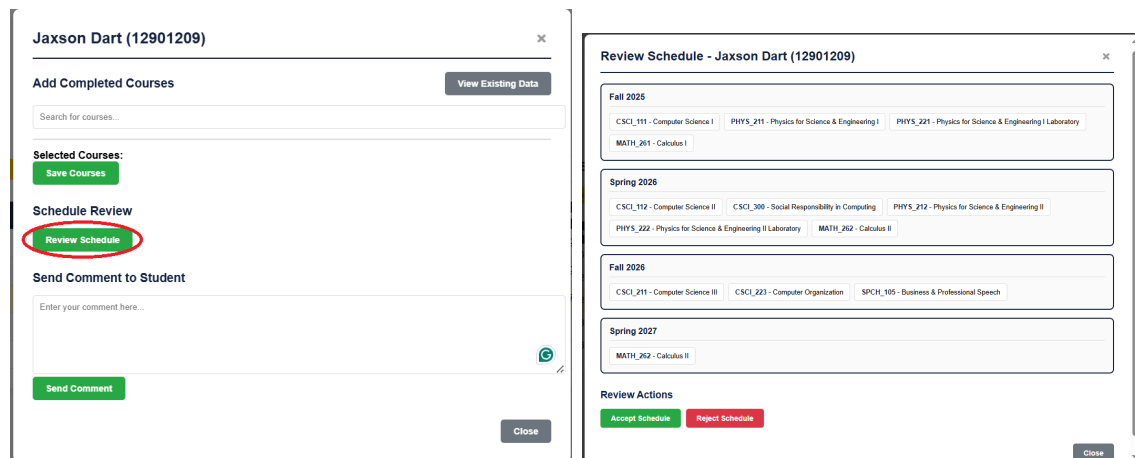
4.2 Reviewing Student Schedules

To review a student's proposed schedule:

1. Select the student from the advisor's student list.



2. Open the submitted schedule in the central view.
3. Use the notes field to provide feedback; these comments will appear in the student's portal.
4. Use the **Accept** button to approve the schedule, or **Request Changes** to send it back with notes.



4.3 Change Log

Advisors can view a complete change log for programs and course requirement updates. The change log shows the timestamp, author, and description of each change.

[← Back to Main](#)

Curriculum Changes

Filter by Type: All Changes Reload

Change #yV2mkrXJ
MAJOR

Date: 11/23/2025, 11:07:52 AM Faculty: faculty@university.edu

DESCRIPTION:
Summary of Changes: | First Year Writing II: Removed 1 course(s): MATH_319 | Social Science (6 hours): Removed 1 course(s): LIBA_313

FACULTY NOTES:
Removed math

ID: yV2mkrXJdrizDPx1fR9u

Change #l8b8915r
COURSE

Date: 11/23/2025, 10:47:14 AM Faculty: faculty@university.edu

DESCRIPTION:
Changed semester from "Fall" to "Spring" | Updated prerequisites

FACULTY NOTES:
Updated prereq

4.3.1 Advisor Dashboard

4.3.2 Student List and Filters

The student list is the primary navigation for advisors to find and manage assigned students. Use the search bar, filters, and sorting to narrow the list.

Common controls and columns:

- **Search:** Search by name, student ID, or email.
- **Filters:** Filter by major, academic standing, or schedules pending review.
- **Columns:** Name, Major, GPA (if available), Last Submission Date, Status, and Quick Actions.
- **Quick Actions:** View profile, open latest submission, or send a message.

Advisor Portal

Logout

Curriculum Changes

Review Courses

Your Students

Show Pending Reviews

student

Student ID	Name	Email	Major	Graduation Date
12312332	Student Test2	student2@olemiss.edu	BSCS	N/A
12345678	Test Student	test@olemiss.edu	BSCS	N/A

4.3.3 Review Dialog and Actions

When opening a student's submission, advisors see a detailed review dialog containing the submitted schedule, course metadata, and any attached student notes.

Review flow:

1. Inspect the submitted terms and courses in a read-only schedule pane.
2. Use the comment field to add targeted feedback on courses or terms.
3. Choose **Approve** to finalize the schedule or **Request Changes** to return it to the student with comments.
4. Optionally attach recommended course substitutions or links to relevant resources.

Review Schedule - Jaxson Dart (12901209) ✕

Fall 2025

CSCI_111 - Computer Science I PHYS_211 - Physics for Science & Engineering I PHYS_221 - Physics for Science & Engineering I Laboratory

MATH_261 - Calculus I

Spring 2026

CSCI_112 - Computer Science II CSCI_300 - Social Responsibility in Computing PHYS_212 - Physics for Science & Engineering II

PHYS_222 - Physics for Science & Engineering II Laboratory MATH_262 - Calculus II

Fall 2026

CSCI_211 - Computer Science III CSCI_223 - Computer Organization SPCH_105 - Business & Professional Speech

Spring 2027

MATH_262 - Calculus II

Review Actions

Accept Schedule Reject Schedule

Close

4.3.4 Messaging and Notes

Advisors can send targeted messages to students either from the student list, profile view, or within a submission review. Messages are threaded and stored with reference to the related submission when applicable.

Messaging features:

- Threaded view with timestamps and sender labels.
- Ability to attach links or references to program requirements and course pages.
- Mark messages as resolved to clear them from the advisor's primary dashboard.

Jaxson Dart (12901209) ×

Add Completed Courses View Existing Data

Selected Courses:
No courses selected
Save Courses

Schedule Review
Review Schedule

Send Comment to Student

Send Comment

Close

4.3.5 Change Log Details and Auditing

The change log provides a complete history of program and course requirement modifications. Advisors can filter the change log to show recent updates relevant to their students or export entries for review.

Change log capabilities:

- Filter by date range, author, or program affected.
- View full diff of requirement changes where available.
- Export filtered results to CSV for departmental review.

← Back to Main

Curriculum Changes

Filter by Type: All Changes ▼ Reload

Change #yV2mkrXJ

MAJOR

Date: 11/23/2025, 11:07:52 AM Faculty: faculty@university.edu

DESCRIPTION:

Summary of Changes: | | First Year Writing II: Removed 1 course(s): MATH_319 | Social Science (6 hours): Removed 1 course(s): LIBA_313

FACULTY NOTES:

Removed math

ID: yV2mkrXJdrizDPxd1R9u

Change #l8b8915r

COURSE

Date: 11/23/2025, 10:47:14 AM Faculty: faculty@university.edu

DESCRIPTION:

Changed semester from "Fall" to "Spring" | Updated prerequisites

FACULTY NOTES:

Updated prereq

5 Faculty

5.1 Faculty Portal

Faculty users can view and update majors, course details, and program requirements. The portal provides safe edit capabilities and records every update in the change log.

1. Faculty header: name, department, and logout button.
2. Navigation: **Majors**, **Courses**, **Change Log**.
3. Editing views include form fields for course description, credits, and prerequisites.

5.2 Updating Requirements and Courses

When editing a major or course:

1. Select the major or course from the list.
2. Edit the required fields and click **Save Changes**.
3. All changes are recorded in the change log with the user's details and timestamp.
4. Major-level edits can include adding/removing course requirements and adjusting credit totals.

The image displays two versions of the 'Edit CSCI_111' form. The left version is the standard form with fields for Course Code, Title, Credits, Typical Semester, Description, Prerequisites, and Learning Outcomes. The right version shows the same form with a 'Record Changes' modal dialog open. The modal contains a 'Summary of Changes' section showing 'Changed title from 'CSCI_111' to 'Computer Science I'' and a 'Notes (Required)' section with the note 'Changed course title from CSCI 111 to Computer Science I'.

5.2.1 Faculty Dashboard

The Faculty Dashboard gives a concise view of department-level tasks and recent program activity. Faculty will see pending change requests, recently edited courses, and high-level enrollment notes.

Dashboard elements:

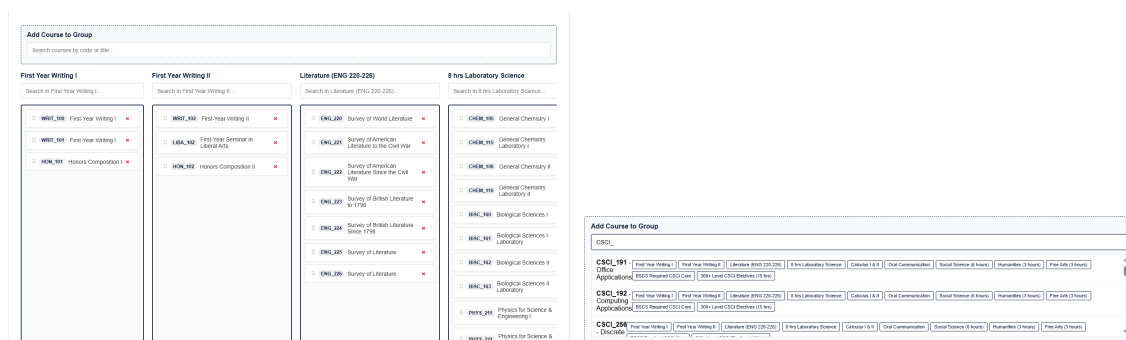
- **Pending Change Requests:** Requests from faculty or admin to modify requirements or course data.
- **Recent Edits:** Quick list of recently edited courses or majors with short descriptions.
- **Department Notices:** Announcements relevant to curriculum changes or deadlines.

5.2.2 Majors Management

Faculty can manage majors through a dedicated Majors view. This view lists all majors under the faculty's purview and allows navigation to edit requirement groups, elective buckets, and credit totals.

Majors view features:

- **List of Majors:** Click to open details for a selected major.
- **Requirement Groups:** View and reorder requirement groups (core, electives, technical electives).
- **Credit Overview:** Summary of total credits required and credits allocated to each group.



5.2.3 Course Editor

The Course Editor provides form-based editing for course properties including title, description, credits, prerequisites, and cross-listings. Edits are validated and previewed before saving.

Course editor capabilities:

- Edit course title, description, and credit hours.
- Update prerequisites and corequisites with autocomplete for course codes.
- Add or remove cross-listed sections and note department ownership.
- Preview the course as it will appear to students prior to saving.

5.2.4 Requirement Editor and Buckets

Faculty can edit requirement buckets (e.g., Core, Electives, Technical) within a major. The editor supports adding/removing courses from buckets and specifying minimum/maximum credit constraints.

Requirement editor features:

- Drag-and-drop interface to move courses into requirement buckets.
- Set bucket constraints such as minimum credit hours or required course counts.
- Mark substitutions or allowed course alternatives for flexibility in degree audits.

5.2.5 Publishing Changes and Approvals

Faculty edits may require departmental review before being published. The system tracks drafts and publishes changes after approvals, recording authorship and timestamps for auditing.

Publishing workflow:

- Save edits as a draft, visible only to editors until submitted for review.
- Submit draft for departmental approval; reviewers can comment or request revisions.
- Once approved, changes are published and recorded in the change log.

5.2.6 Notifications and Collaboration

Faculty receive notifications for review requests, comments on drafts, and system announcements. Collaboration tools include commenting on drafts and linking course changes to program change proposals.

Collaboration features:

- Notification center with quick links to pending drafts and comments.
- Inline comments on draft edits for targeted feedback.
- Export tools to share change summaries with committees or accreditation offices.

6 Admin / Developer Notes

This section provides brief notes for administrators and developers who maintain the system deployment or perform troubleshooting in production.

6.1 Deployment and Configuration

Configuration files are located under ‘src/main/resources’. The ‘application-local.properties’ file contains settings used in local development. When deploying to production, ensure that environment-specific properties are set appropriately, including database credentials and Firebase service account keys.

6.2 Pins and User Roles

To avoid unauthorized creation of advisor or faculty accounts, the application uses simple pin validation in the signup flow. The sample pins in this release are:

extbfAdvisor pin: 1111

extbfFaculty pin: 2222

Contact the devops team to change or rotate pins in a production environment.

6.3 Logs and Monitoring

Application logs are written to the server’s standard log system. For production deployments, configure a centralized log aggregator and alerting (e.g., Splunk, ELK, or Azure Monitor) to track errors and performance.

7 Troubleshooting

7.1 Common Issues

- **Cannot login:** Verify that the user exists and the password is correct. Check for errors in the authentication logs.
- **Schedule approval not reflecting:** Confirm that the advisor action completed successfully and that the student view is refreshed; check server logs for errors.

7.2 Contacting Support

If you encounter an issue that cannot be resolved locally, gather relevant logs, a description of the steps to reproduce, and screenshots where appropriate, then contact the support team at ‘support@planink.example.edu’.

8 Contact

For questions, support, or to report bugs, contact the team at:

- **Braden Dougherty:** bqdoughe@go.olemiss.edu
- **Lucas Landrus:** lklandr1@go.olemiss.edu
- **Christopher Nguyen:** cpnguyen@go.olemiss.edu
- **Abdullah Orynbassa:** aurinbos@go.olemiss.edu

Project Repository: <https://github.com/lklandr1/degreePlanner>